Tabreez, January 17, 1845

If I recollect right my last letter to you was a merry one; this must be a melancholy one. Poor Mrs Bonham died on Monday the 30th Decr after an illness of only five days. She was taken ill on X'mas day, of one of those malignant fevers which are so common in Persia and died early on Monday morning. I have in my life witnessed some distressing scenes but I never saw any thing more distressing than this. For a time Mr Bonham was almost mad. The child of whose Christening I gave you an account of in my last letter was eight months old the day its mother died. A nurse has been procured for him and he is, thank God doing well. The disease of which Mrs Bonham died was declared by the doctor to be of so contagious a nature that he ordered immediate interment. In Persia there are no such things as undertakers. At least none who know how to manage a funeral in the European way. Under these circumstances this duty devolved upon me. About twelve o'clock on the day of the death, M. d'Ozeroff the Russian Consul Genl came to Mr Bonham's and offered to assist me in this most painful duty. I accepted his offer without consulting Mr Bonham who was not in a state to be spoken with, and he remained at the house the rest of the day attending to the most minute details and arranging every thing in a much more decent and proper manner than I could have done. For I, thank God, have had little experience in such matters. It was however near twelve o'clock at night before we could get every-thing ready. And we had to manage every thing so that Mr Bonham should see nothing of what was going on. As it would have been most distressing to him to have seen the coffin brought into the house the black scarfs and all the rest of this melancholy business. We so arranged it that he neither saw nor heard any thing. A grave was prepared inside the Armenian church in this town. And when everything was ready I told Mr Bonham and contrary to my expectations he insisted upon accompanying the body to the grave; I wished the doctor to prevent this as I did not think he was able to do it, and the doctor in his capacity could *command,* I, as a friend could only *advise.* The event proved that I was not much mistaken. The cold was most intense and the streets in many places were blocked up with ice and snow. At near midnight on Monday the procession moved out of the house in the following order. First went the Armenian priests in their gold and silver brocade robes, with large wax tapers lanterns etc chanting the service of their church. Then came a number of people with torches on long poles and lanterns, then the body carried by M. d'Ozeroff's Cossacks in uniform, then M. d'Ozeroff and I; next Mr Bonham supported by the doctor and other Europeans, his friends; then a long line of Christians of various denominations such as Russians, Georgians, Greeks and Armenians, who notwithstanding the inclemency of the weather, came uninvited

Generated on 2020-09-16 00:02 GMT / https://hdl.handle.net/2027/mdp.39015035112393
Public Domain, Google-digitized / http://www.hathitrust.org/access_use#pd-google
Digitized by Google
Original from UNIVERSITY OF MICHIGAN